

Kerem Zaman

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EDUCATION

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Chapel Hill, NC, USA

PhD in Computer Science (2022 - Present)

Advisor: Prof. Shashank Srivastava

Boğaziçi University

Istanbul, Turkey

BSc in Computer Engineering (2018 - 2022)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Interpretable and explainable machine learning, AI safety, LLMs, multilingual NLP, fairness, synthetic data generation

PUBLICATIONS

Is Chain-of-Thought Really Not Explainability? Chain-of-Thought Can Be Faithful without Hint Verbalization

[Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

Under Review

Optimization-Free Image Immunization Against Diffusion-Based Editing

Tarik Can Ozden, Ozgur Kara, Oguzhan Akcin, [Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava, Sandeep P. Chinchali, James M. Rehg

ICLR 2026

A Causal Lens for Evaluating Faithfulness Metrics

[Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2025

INTERACT: Enabling Interactive, Question-Driven Learning in Large Language Models

Aum Kendapadi*, [Kerem Zaman](#)*, Rakesh R Menon*, Shashank Srivastava

ACL 2025 [ORAL PRESENTATION]

Fuse to Forget: Bias Reduction and Selective Memorization through Model Fusion

[Kerem Zaman](#), Leshem Choshen, Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2024

MaNtLE: Model-agnostic Natural Language Explainer

Rakesh R Menon, [Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2023

A Multilingual Perspective Towards the Evaluation of Attribution Methods

[Kerem Zaman](#), Yonatan Belinkov

EMNLP 2022 [ORAL PRESENTATION]

Rank in Style: A Ranking-based Approach to Find Interpretable Directions in StyleGAN

Umut Kocasarı*, [Kerem Zaman](#)*, Mert Tiftikci*, Pinar Yanardag

CVPR 2022 5th Workshop on Computer Vision for Fashion, Art, and Design

BURST: Software and Simulation Solutions of an Autonomous Vehicle

Fatih Köse, İbrahim Özcan, Melih Dal, Metehan Yıldırım, Kadir Türksoy, [Kerem Zaman](#), Tuna Meral, Sinan Öncü

2020 28th Signal Processing and Communications Applications Conference (SIU), Gaziantep, Turkey, pp. 1-4

EXPERIENCE

UNC-NLP

Chapel Hill, NC, USA

Graduate Research Assistant | Advisor: Shashank Srivastava

August 2022 - Present

Working on explainable NLP, faithfulness of natural language explanations, safety, fairness and model merging

IFM MBZUAI Silicon Valley Lab

Sunnyvale, CA, USA

AI Engineering Intern | Advisor: Mikhail Yurochkin

May 2025 - August 2025

Worked on improving domain-specific reasoning abilities of LLMs by generating synthetic mid-training data through self-play

CATLAB at Bogazici University

Istanbul, Turkey

Undergraduate Research Assistant | Advisor: Pinar Yanardag

October 2021 - June 2022

Worked on improvement of text-based image manipulations for GANs by utilizing automatically extracted masks and improved text generation strategies

Independent Research

Remote

Advisor: Yonatan Belinkov

April 2021 - June 2022

Worked on evaluating wide variety of attribution methods on the NLI task along with introducing a novel method for faithfulness evaluation

Independent Research

Remote

Advisor: Tolga Birdal

September 2021 - September 2022

Worked on Riemannian replacement of GANs and the concepts like interpolation, random walk and latent manipulation

PragmaCraft

Istanbul, Turkey

Software Engineer / Software Engineer Intern

July 2018 - June 2022

Worked on diverse NLP tasks, including retrieval, QA, NER, summarization, and text classification, covering the full lifecycle from training models from scratch to deployment and optimization.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- Reviewer at ICLR 2025, ACL Rolling Review (ARR) 2024-2025, DaSH Workshop @ EMNLP 2022
- Outstanding Reviewer at EMNLP 2025 (<1%)

SKILLS

- **Programming Languages:** Python, C/C++
- **Technologies:** Git, ROS, Gazebo, MongoDB, Docker
- **Libraries:** PyTorch, numpy, scikit-learn, OpenCV, Transformers, vLLM
- **Familiar with:** HTML, CSS, Javascript, SQL, C#, Verilog, LaTeX, AWS
- **Human Languages:** Turkish (native), English (advanced), Laz (elementary), Ancient Egyptian (elementary), German (elementary)

OTHER

- **Bogazici University Robotic Systems Team Autonomous EV project (2018 - 2022)** : Led Autonomous Software Team between 2020-2022, developed path planning and control systems, took part in traffic sign detection module, realized and tested them in simulation environment and on the real vehicle.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE & ACHIEVEMENTS

- Most Original Software Award for Unique Vehicle Category at Teknofest Robotaxi-Full Scale Autonomous Vehicle Competition 2021
- 1st place in Preliminary Design and Simulation Stage at Teknofest Robotaxi-Full Scale Autonomous Vehicle Competition 2019 & 2020
- 242nd place among 2M+ students in University Entrance Exam (2018)
- 3rd place in Istanbul-Asia Region in TUBITAK (Scientific and Technological Research Council of Turkey) Research Projects Challenge for High School Students
- Gave introductory programming courses in high school organizations